ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

How to Study at University: A First-Semester System That Works

Replace secondary-school cramming with a repeatable weekly study routine

STUDY SKILLS

Study Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

University rewards independent work, and many freshers keep using a method built for supervised secondary school. This pack sets out a weekly system: preparing before lectures, processing notes after them, and revising in spaced cycles instead of one desperate week.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain how university assessment differs from secondary-school assessment.
- Build a weekly timetable that covers all courses without cramming.
- Use pre-lecture, during-lecture and post-lecture routines.
- Choose study techniques supported by evidence rather than comfort.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What changed

At university you are responsible for noticing what you do not understand.

- Lectures cover selected material; reading and practice fill the gaps.
- Assessment is often cumulative and less predictable than WAEC-style papers.
- Nobody checks your notes weekly, so weaknesses surface late.
- Continuous assessment, assignments and attendance carry marks.
- The volume is larger, so passive reading cannot keep pace.
- A system beats motivation: you need a routine that works on bad days.

The weekly cycle

Treat each course as a cycle rather than a single event.

1. Before the lecture, skim the topic for ten minutes and write two questions.
2. During the lecture, capture structure and examples, not a transcript.
3. Within a day, rewrite the notes in your own words and fill gaps from a textbook.
4. Two days later, test yourself without notes.
5. At the weekend, do practice questions and update your weak-topic list.
6. Before the next lecture, review the previous week for five minutes.

> **The two-day rule**
> If you have not revisited a lecture within two days, you are effectively learning it again from scratch. Short, early reviews save hours later.

Techniques that earn their place

Use methods with evidence behind them and drop techniques that only feel productive.

- Retrieval practice: close the book and write what you remember.
- Spaced repetition: revisit at increasing intervals rather than rereading repeatedly.
- Interleaving: mix problem types so you learn to choose a method, not just apply one.
- Elaboration: explain why a fact is true and connect it to what you know.
- Avoid highlighting as a primary method; it produces recognition, not recall.
- Study in 40-minute blocks with short breaks and a phone out of reach.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why is rereading a weak study method?

Answer: It creates a feeling of familiarity without testing retrieval, so it produces weak long-term memory.

2. What is interleaving?

Answer: Mixing different problem types or topics in one study session so learners practise choosing the right approach.

3. Name two things to do within 24 hours of a lecture.

Answer: Rewrite notes in your own words and self-test on the main points without notes.

4. Why does a study timetable beat studying when motivated?

Answer: It removes the need to decide and protects study time on low-motivation days.

5. How should you handle a topic you do not understand?

Answer: Write a specific question, consult the recommended text, then ask your lecturer or course rep, and record the answer.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Draw a weekly timetable with fixed study blocks for every course.
- [ ] Write your lecture routine in three steps and follow it for one week.
- [ ] Choose two evidence-based techniques and use them for seven days.
- [ ] Create a weak-topic list and update it weekly.
- [ ] Try one 40-minute focus block with the phone switched off.
- [ ] Review the week every Sunday and adjust the plan.
- [ ] Compare notes with a coursemate and fill one gap each.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: